



Figure 1: Tasks in Task Manager organised in two rows

control), Klipper (clipboard), and perhaps a software update notifier too. The tray now looks like, well...a tray, due to it being confined by a boundary. Also, you can right click on its edge to get a hold of the *System Tray Settings* menu, from where you can select icons of the running apps you want to be auto hidden. After you've made your selections, the size of the system tray will get shortened, and the left side of the tray will display an arrow pointing left, indicating you can expand it in that direction. This option comes in handy if you run a lot of apps that place a control icon inside the system tray, thus expanding the tray to occupy the precious panel space.

The task manager has also got a bit of a facelift—it can now again group applications based on program names, and placing the tasks on multiple rows is also possible just like in KDE3. All this can be configured from the *Task Manager Settings* menu by right clicking on the panel. Although, I have no complaints about how grouping works, when you organise tasks in rows, the default teaming makes it look a bit odd—as if someone has shrunk the tasks forcefully (Figure 1). However, I'm sure this would be addressed in a bug fix release soon, as it looks like a theme issue. Also, by default, while tasks are sorted in alphabetical order (and not in the order programs are launched) I've enabled it to let me sort stuff manually. This enables me to drag and reorganise my programs as I wish.

In addition to all this, more options have been added to the general settings of the overall panel. Things like how to increase the height, position and screen-edge can be much more easily achieved now, unlike in KDE 4.1, where it was much harder to guess how to go about things.

Coming back to those who're on the move, right click on the



Figure 2: My personal desktop with Folder View, Comic Strip, Notes and Picture Frame widgets

Battery Monitor widget (should be somewhere near your clock), and you'll see configurable options galore. This is thanks to the integration of the *PowerDevil* utility, another addition in this release. It offers various pre-configured 'Power Profiles'—viz. performance, powersave, aggressive powersave, presentation, etc.—and lets you fine tune all the profiles as per your liking. Overall, although it's pretty easy to use and understand the options, KDE4 seems to drain out a lot of battery power compared to KDE3 and GNOME.

As for the default KDE4 menu, Kickoff, it hasn't got any visually noticeable feature additions, apart from the border colour, which is now black, to gel with the rest of the Oxygen theme.

Workspace

As for the other part of the desktop, which is the main workspace, things have again been refined a lot with respect to the widgets, and their numbers have also increased

considerably. Figure 2 shows what my personal desktop screen looks like, while Figure 3 shows my work laptop. As you can see on my personal desktop, I have the Folder View widget, a Calvin and Hobbs comic strip, plus a few pictures of my family members.

The Folder View widget, as you know, was introduced in KDE 4.1. You configure it to point towards the contents of the folder you access frequently, right on your desktop—so there's no need to use the file manager to hunt down *that* folder every time you need something; however deep inside the filesystem it is located, you can see its contents right on your desktop. You can also have multiple Folder Views, say *~/Documents* and *~/Pictures* folders, for easy access.

Traditionally, the contents of the *~/Desktop* folder are displayed as icons on your desktop. Well, by default, the Folder View widget displays the contents of this folder. In fact, if you like, in KDE 4.2 you can even make your desktop imitate